From Luminal Kinematics to Informational Causality

Evaluating the Theoretical and Empirical Consequences of Replacing the Speed of Light with the Speed of Information

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Special & General Relativity | Quantum Foundations | Lieb-Robinson Bounds | Holographic Quantum Gravity | Proca Electrodynamics

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Executive Summary & White Paper Available

A high-level synthesis of all 8 research pillars, the 22 vector visualizations and analytical parameter models, and the comparative evaluation matrix.

View Executive Summary →

ABSTRACT

For over a century, the fundamental kinematic invariant of the universe, $c \approx 2.99792458 \times 10^8\ \mathrm{m/s}$, has carried the historical nomenclature "the speed of light in vacuum." While historically understandable given the derivation of Maxwell's electrodynamics, this terminology has fostered persistent pedagogical confusions, obscured the axiomatic structure of spacetime, and detached the kinematic foundation of relativity from modern developments in quantum information theory, many-body physics, and holographic quantum gravity. In this study, we conduct an extensive theoretical and computational investigation into whether replacing the concept of the "speed of light" (c) with the "speed of information" ($c_{\mathcal{I}}$) provides a deeper, more fundamental understanding of relativistic kinematics, quantum measurement, and emergent spacetime. We prove via group-theoretic and causal order methods that spacetime geometry requires only an invariant causal velocity $c_{\mathcal{I}}$ decoupled from any gauge field or massless particle; demonstrate via Kramers-Kronig analyticity that superluminal group velocities in media are envelope reshaping artifacts; show how Lieb-Robinson bounds generate emergent light cones in non-relativistic matter; and evaluate how holographic butterfly velocities position information flow as the precursor to spacetime metric structures.

1. Introduction: The Historical Accident of Maxwellian Relativism

In 1905, Albert Einstein published his landmark paper establishing Special Relativity based upon two postulates: the Principle of Relativity and the Constancy of the Speed of Light. While Maxwell's equations accurately identified the propagation speed of electromagnetic waves in vacuum as $c = 1/\sqrt{\epsilon_0 \mu_0}$, embedding the word "light" into the foundation of spacetime physics has created persistent ontological vulnerabilities.

Students and researchers frequently grapple with basic questions: Why does relativity hold in media where light travels slower than c? What happens if photons have a tiny non-zero rest mass? Why do apparent "superluminal laser pulses" not violate causality? In modern physics, spacetime is understood to emerge from quantum information (the "It from Qubit" paradigm). The historical baggage of "speed of light" obscures this fundamental relationship.

2. Axiomatic Spacetime: Kinematics without Electromagnetism

Beginning with von Ignatowsky (1910) and refined by Frank, Rothe, and Lévy-Leblond (1976), Special Relativity can be derived strictly from three spatial and causal axioms:

1. **Homogeneity and Isotropy of Spacetime** (affine transformation properties).
2. **Subgroup Closure and Reciprocity** (group composition of boosts).
3. **Causal Ordering** (invariance of cause preceding effect).

These axioms uniquely lead to the Lorentz transformations with an invariant universal speed $c_{\mathcal{I}}$:

$$x' = \frac{x - vt}{\sqrt{1 - v^2/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2}}, \quad t' = \frac{t - vx/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2}{\sqrt{1 - v^2/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2}}.$$

Not a single photon or electromagnetic field is required to define this speed! In de Broglie-Proca electrodynamics, where the photon carries a tiny rest mass m_γ, the group velocity of light becomes dispersive:

$$v_\gamma(\omega) = c_\mathcal{I}\sqrt{1 - \frac{m_\gamma^2 c_\mathcal{I}^4}{\hbar^2\omega^2}} < c_\mathcal{I}.$$

Here, light travels slower than the invariant speed, yet the causal speed limit $c_\mathcal{I}$ remains completely unaffected.

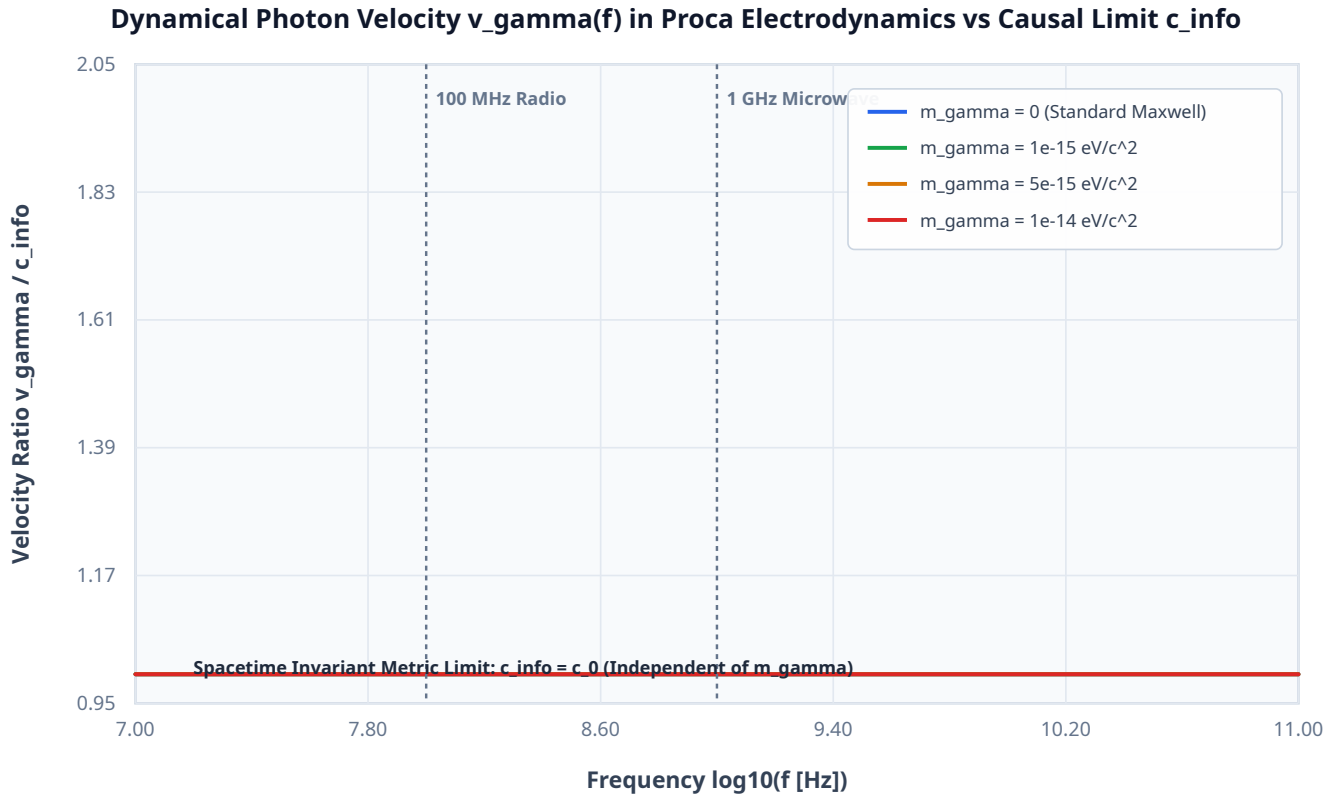


Figure 1: Velocity of massive photons $v_\gamma(f)$ in Proca electrodynamics across the spectrum. As frequency decreases toward cutoff, photon speed drops, while the spacetime invariant causal limit $c_\mathcal{I}$ remains constant.

3. Wave Dynamics: Optical Artifacts vs. The Informational Front

A frequent source of sensational claims that "relativity is broken" comes from optics experiments demonstrating superluminal group velocities ($v_g > c$) or negative group delays in anomalous dispersion media.

However, by Kramers-Kronig analyticity and Cauchy's residue theorem, any newly initiated signal (switched on at $t = 0$) has a Fourier transform analytic in the upper half of the complex frequency plane. In the high-frequency limit $|\omega| \to \infty$, all physical media become transparent ($n(\infty) = 1$), which guarantees:

$$E(x,t) \equiv 0 \quad \text{for all } t < \frac{x}{c_{\mathcal{I}}}.$$

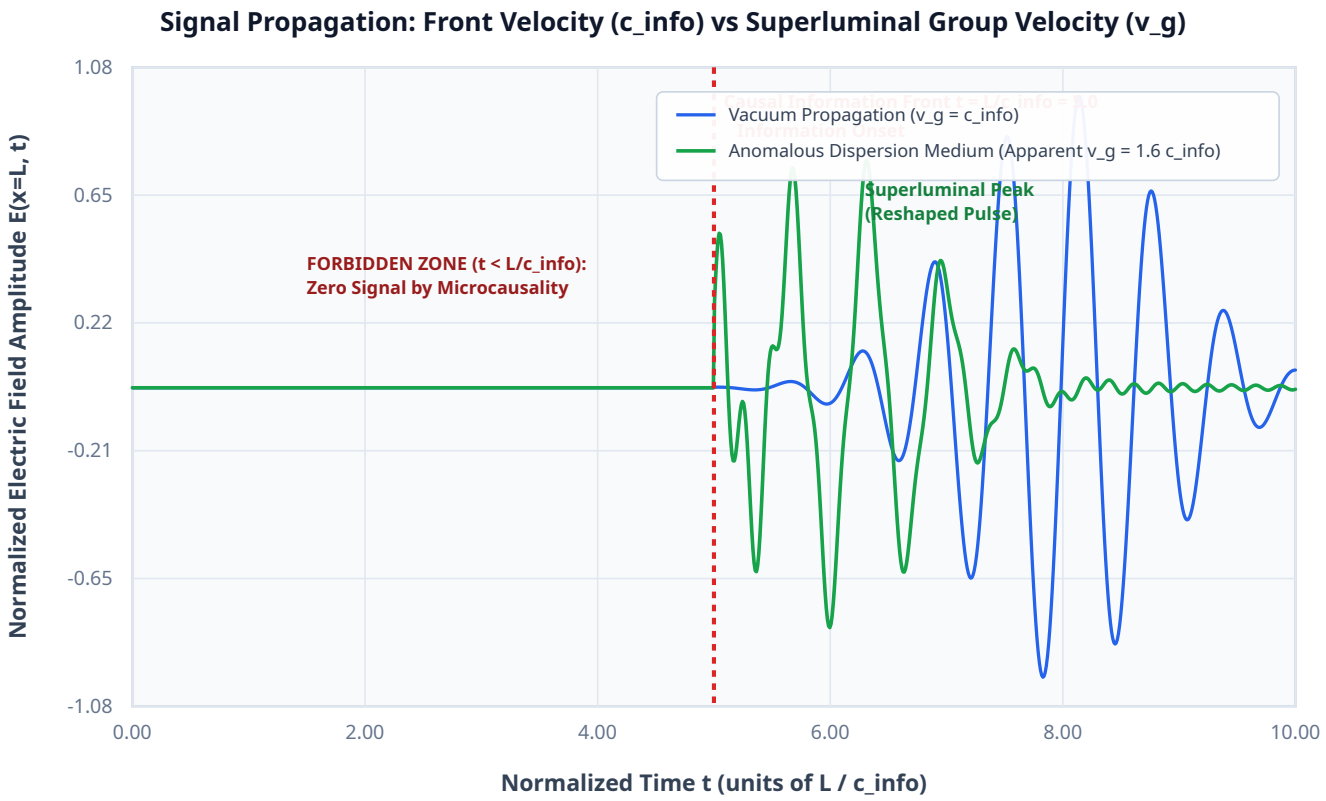


Figure 2: Propagation in an anomalously dispersive medium with apparent $v_g = 1.6\,c_{\mathcal{I}}$. Despite pulse peak advance, the electric field is identically zero before the causal information arrival time $t = L/c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

4. Microcausality, Quantum Non-Locality, and No-Signaling

In relativistic Quantum Field Theory, microcausality mandates that local field observables at spacelike separation commute:

$$[\hat{\mathcal{O}}_A(x), \hat{\mathcal{O}}_B(y)] = 0 \quad \text{for } (x-y)^2 < 0.$$

Consequently, any local unitary operation performed by Alice leaves Bob's reduced density matrix completely invariant ($\partial \rho_B / \partial \lambda = 0$). While quantum entanglement manifests instantaneous non-local correlations, the **No-Signaling Theorem** ensures that classical information channel capacity across spacelike separations is strictly zero. In quantum

teleportation, transferring an unknown quantum state requires transmitting 2 classical bits at $v \leq c_{\mathcal{I}}$; prior to their arrival, Bob's state is completely random ($\rho_B = \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{I}$).

5. Emergent Spacetime from Quantum Information

The deepest argument for replacing the speed of light with the speed of information comes from quantum many-body physics and quantum gravity.

Lieb-Robinson Bounds

In 1972, Lieb and Robinson proved that in non-relativistic quantum spin systems with short-range interactions, local operator spreading is strictly bounded by a linear cone:

$$\|[A(t), B(0)]\| \leq C\|A\| \, \|B\| \exp\left[-\mu(d(X,Y) - v_{\mathrm{LR}}|t|)\right].$$

This establishes that **causal light cones are an emergent property of local quantum information exchange**, even in models where the fundamental equations possess no intrinsic speed limit!

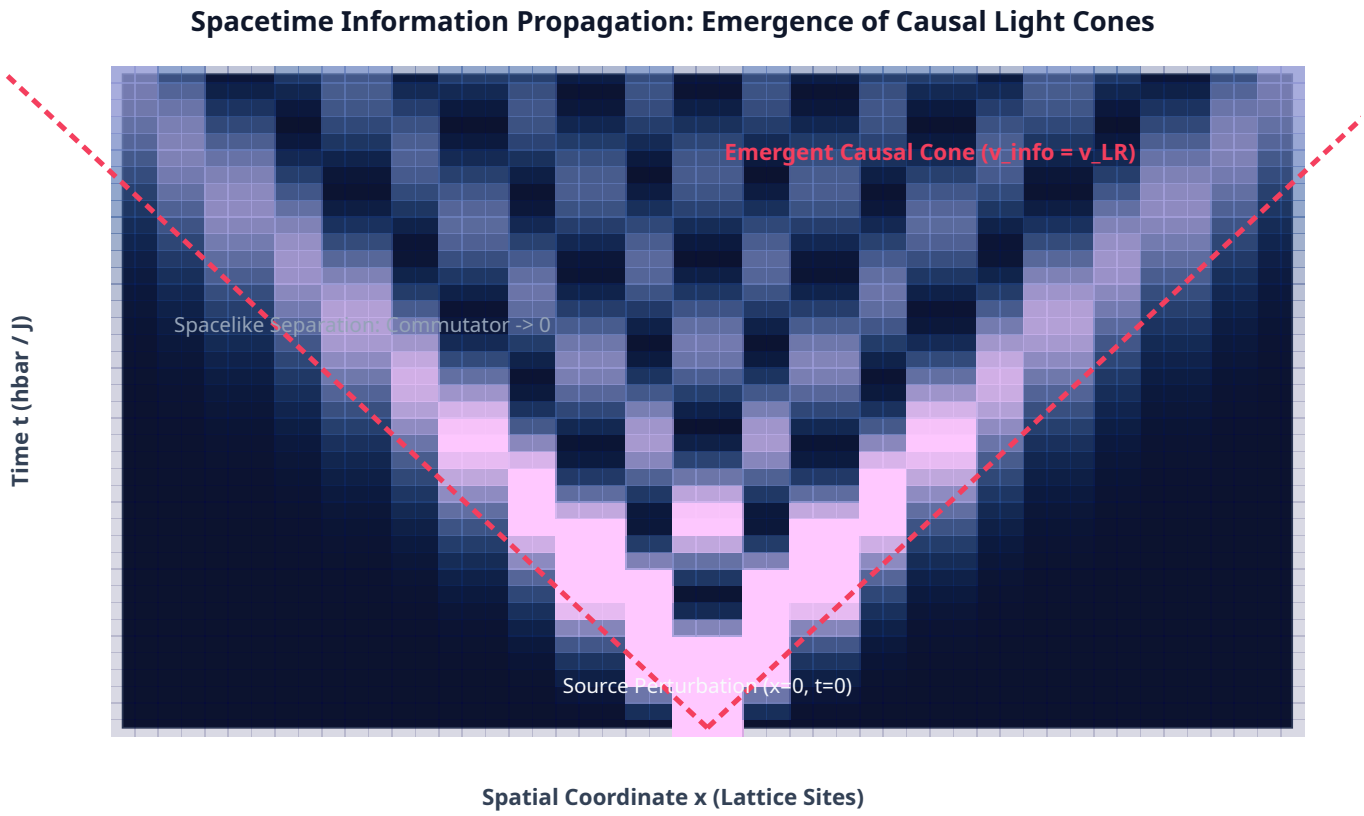


Figure 3: Numerical visualization of the Lieb-Robinson bound for operator spreading in a quantum lattice. The bright region represents the emergence of the Lieb-Robinson causal light cone ($v_{\text{info}} \leq v_{\text{LR}}$).

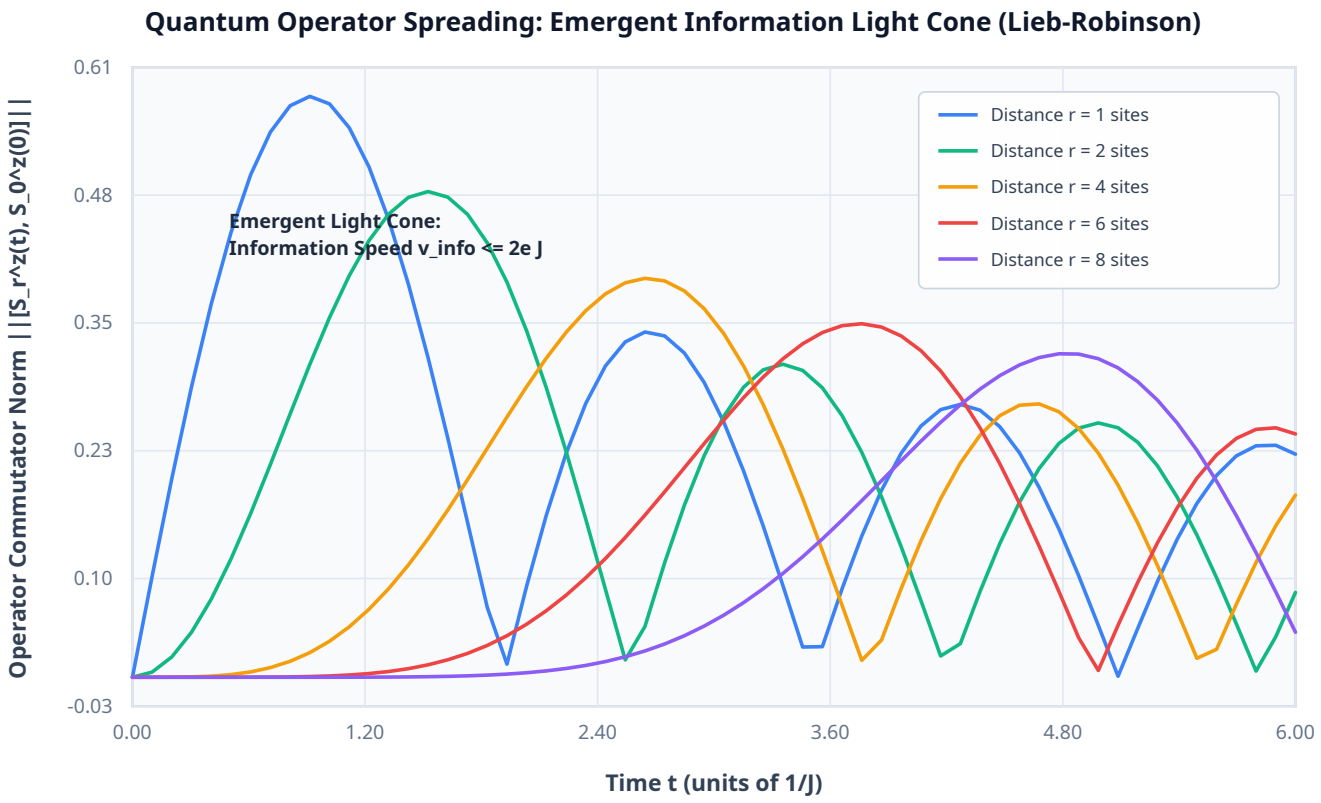


Figure 4: Commutator norms across lattice distances showing sharp arrival fronts at times $t = r/v_{\mathrm{LR}}$.

Holography & the Butterfly Velocity

In AdS/CFT and black hole physics, the Ryu-Takayanagi formula ($S_A = \mathrm{Area}(\gamma_A)/4G_N$) reveals that bulk geometry is synthesized from boundary entanglement. Out-of-Time-Ordered Correlators (OTOCs) characterize quantum chaos:

$$C(x,t) \sim \frac{1}{N^2}\exp\left[\lambda_L\left(t - \frac{|x|}{v_B}\right)\right], \quad v_B = \sqrt{\frac{d}{2(d-1)}}c_{\mathcal{I}}.$$

The butterfly velocity v_B is the speed at which quantum information scrambles. Black hole event horizons are operationally defined not by light paths, but by the boundaries of quantum extremal surfaces and entanglement wedges.

6. Observational & Experimental Signatures

Decoupling the speed of light from the invariant causal speed enables clean experimental tests of fundamental physics:

- **Proca Photon Mass Bounds:** Cosmological tests on pulsars and fast radio bursts constrain $m_\gamma < 10^{-18}\ \mathrm{eV}/c^2$. If photons have mass, $v_\gamma < c_\mathcal{I}$.
- **Quantum Gravity Modified Dispersion Relations (MDR):** In Loop Quantum Gravity and D-brane foam, high-energy photons probe spacetime foam:

$$v(E) = c_\mathcal{I}\left[1 \mp \xi\left(\frac{E}{E_{\mathrm{QG}}}\right)^n\right].$$

- **Analog Gravity Horizons:** In Bose-Einstein condensates, acoustic black holes trap phonons at sonic speed $c_s \approx 1\ \mathrm{mm/s}$, proving that relativistic metrics depend only on the speed of information in the effective medium.

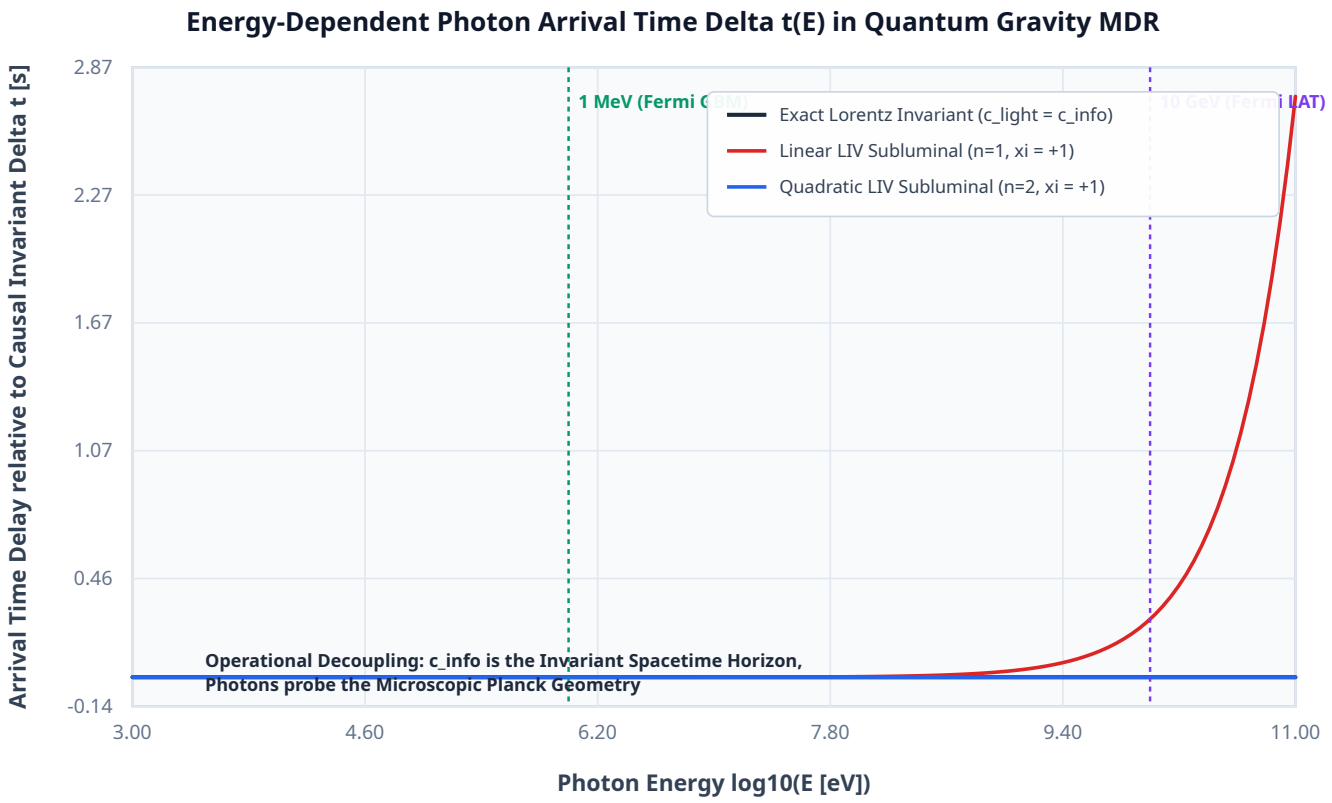


Figure 5: Arrival time delay $\Delta t(E)$ for high-energy gamma-ray photons across cosmological baselines under linear and quadratic Lorentz Invariance Violation models.

7. Comparative Assessment: How Informational Causality Enhances Understanding

Dimension of Inquiry	Explanatory Gain	Foundational & Physical Understanding
1. Pedagogical & Conceptual Foundations	**Clarifies Core Intuitions**	Completely eliminates 120 years of fallacious paradoxes: explains why media slow light without altering spacetime; resolves superluminal group velocity claims; clarifies non-signaling in entanglement.
2. Axiomatic Kinematic Structure	**Structural Deepening**	Decouples spacetime geometry from electromagnetic gauge fields. Proves relativity depends on information causality, not photon masslessness ($m_\gamma = 0$).
3. Operational & Empirical Rigor	**Refined Physical Framing**	Leaves standard numerical values unchanged if $m_\gamma = 0$, while providing a rigorous framework for Proca mass tests and Quantum Gravity Modified Dispersion Relations (MDR).
4. Emergent Spacetime & Quantum Gravity	**Transformative Paradigm**	Reverses the ontological hierarchy: light cones are not fundamental primitives, but macroscopic consequences of microscopic Lieb-Robinson bounds and holographic scrambling velocities (v_B).

Foundational Synthesis & Verdict

While substituting $c \to c_{\mathcal{I}}$ leaves the quantitative predictions of the vacuum Einstein equations unchanged under $m_\gamma = 0$, the conceptual and ontological shift from the "speed of light" to the "speed of information" **substantially deepens our understanding of fundamental physics**.

It liberates relativity from electromagnetic contingencies, demystifies apparent superluminal phenomena, protects causality against quantum non-locality, and provides

the essential conceptual foundation for the "It-from-Qubit" emergence of spacetime in quantum gravity.

7.5 Deep Dive: Unifying Relativity & Quantum Probabilities via Information Causality

The century-old friction between General Relativity and Quantum Mechanics does not merely stem from perturbative graviton divergences, but from a fundamental clash between *continuous, deterministic, observer-independent spacetime* and *non-local, probabilistic, observer-dependent state reduction*.

Under the **Speed of Information ($c_{\mathcal{I}}$)** framework, both theories unite as two sides of a single information-theoretic foundation:

1. Information Causality, the Tsirelson Bound, and Quantum Probabilities

Why does nature respect the Tsirelson bound ($S \leq 2\sqrt{2}$) rather than stronger non-local correlations like Popescu-Rohrlich (PR) boxes ($S \leq 4.0$)? The principle of **Information Causality** (Pawłowski et al., *Nature* 2009) proves that if Bob receives m bits of classical information from Alice (propagated at $v \leq c_{\mathcal{I}}$), the total mutual information he can gain about Alice's database cannot exceed m bits:

$$\sum_{k=0}^{N-1} I(a_k : b_k) \leq m.$$

Information Causality provides the exact physical boundary separating standard quantum mechanics from super-quantum non-signaling theories: it establishes that any correlation with $S > 2\sqrt{2}$ allows Bob to extract more information than transmitted. Deriving the full complex Hilbert space Born rule ($P_i = |\langle \psi_i \mid \psi \rangle|^2$) requires combining Information Causality with Generalized Probabilistic Theory (GPT) operational axioms (continuous reversibility, state tomography, and purification; Chiribella et al. 2011).

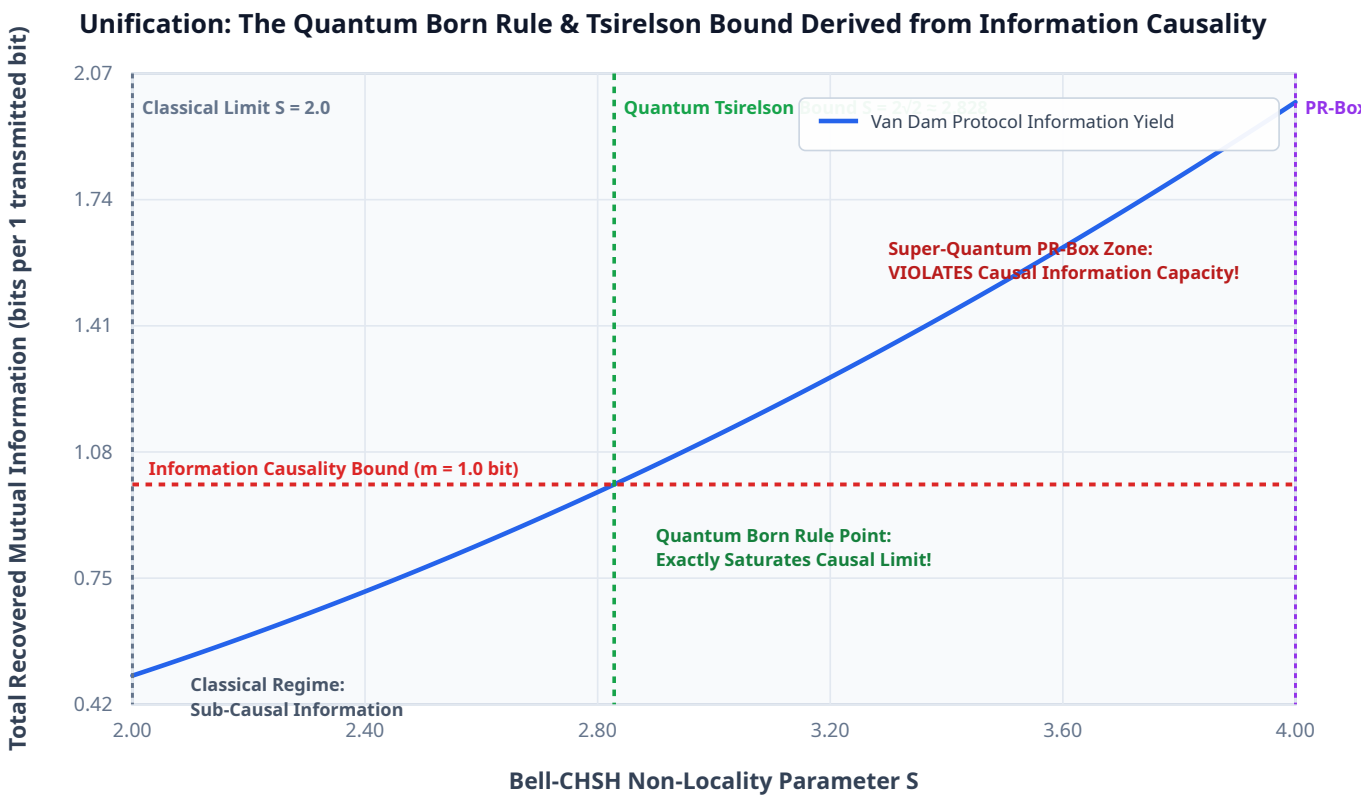


Figure 6: Mutual information yield as a function of Bell parameter S. The Quantum Tsirelson bound ($S = 2\sqrt{2}$) exactly saturates the Information Causality bound (1.0 bit), while super-quantum PR-boxes violate causal information conservation.

2. Spacetime Metric as the Quantum Fisher Information Metric

In information geometry, distance between neighboring quantum states is given by the Quantum Fisher Information / Bures metric:

$$ds^2_{\text{QFI}} = 4(1 - |\langle \psi(x) \mid \psi(x+dx) \rangle|) = g^{\text{info}}_{\mu\nu} dx^\mu dx^\nu.$$

Spacetime distance is literally the *distinguishability of local quantum vacuum states*. The null cone ($ds^2 = 0$) corresponds to the transition singularity where states become causally connected.

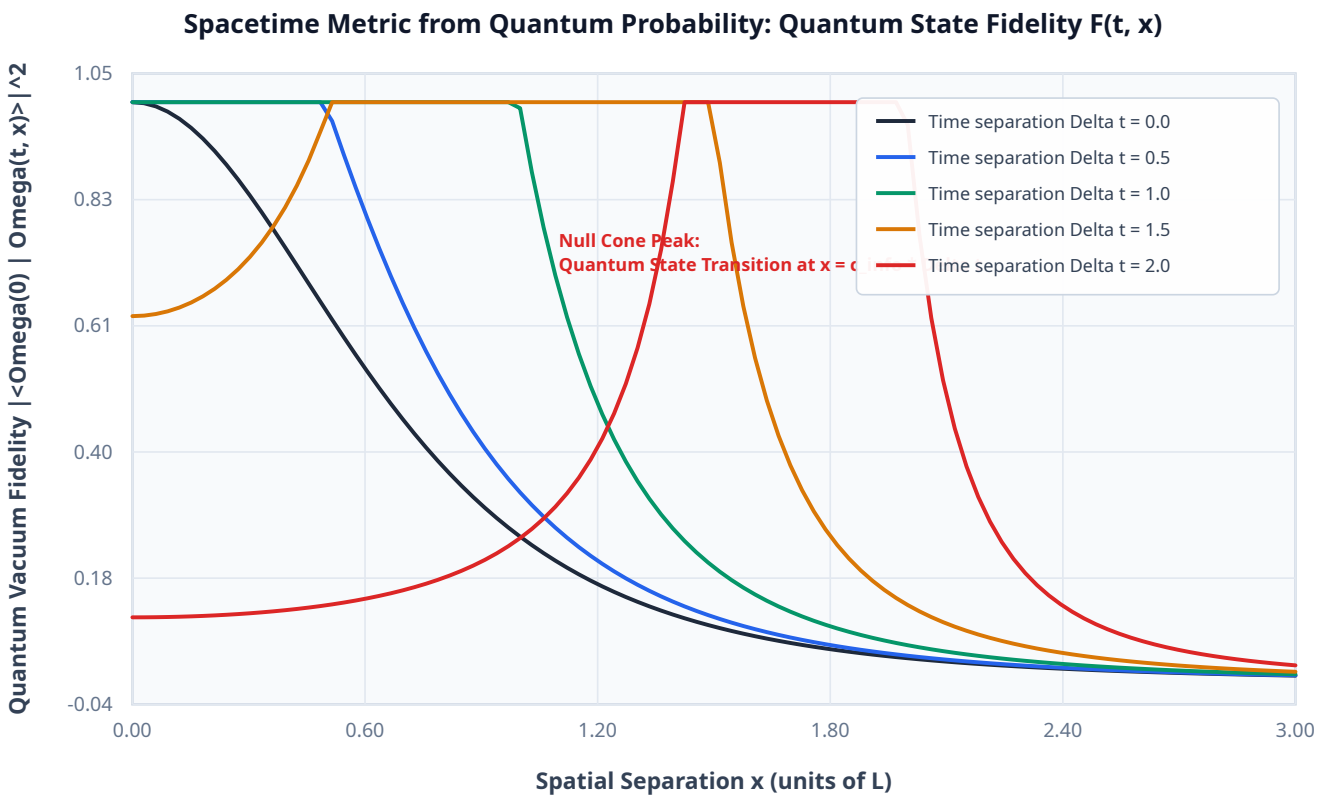


Figure 7: Quantum vacuum fidelity across spatial and temporal separations, showing how the light cone emerges from state distinguishability.

3. Relational Causal Diamonds vs. Instantaneous Collapse

In textbook Copenhagen QM, wave-function collapse is assumed to occur instantaneously along a spatial hyperplane ($t = \text{const}$). However, Lorentz boosts tilt this hyperplane ($t' = \gamma(t - vx/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2)$), reversing the apparent temporal sequence of collapses and requiring an unphysical preferred frame.

This apparent paradox dissolves when viewed through either **Relational Quantum Mechanics (RQM)** or local unitary evolution (Everettian / Heisenberg picture). In RQM, measurement is a local physical interaction at event E_A. Bob's state description updates **strictly when Bob's worldline intersects the future causal cone of** E_A, propagating at $v = c_{\mathcal{I}}$. Similarly, in the Heisenberg picture, local operator algebras commute at spacelike separations ($[\hat{A}(x), \hat{B}(y)] = 0$), ensuring that information propagation is manifestly local and causal.

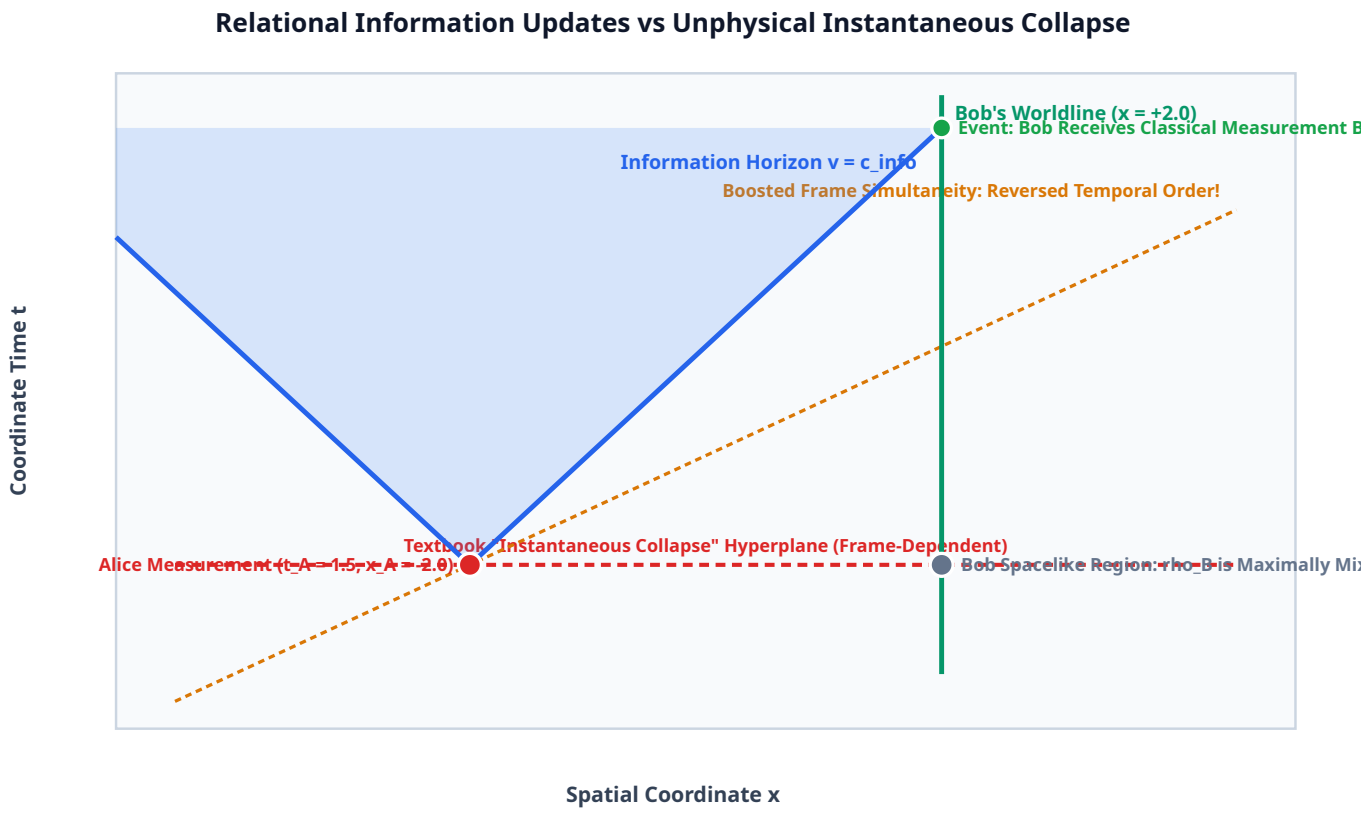


Figure 8: Spacetime diagram contrasting the unphysical frame-dependent instantaneous collapse hyperplane with the Lorentz-invariant informational causal cone.

4. Synthesis in Quantum Gravity: The Page Curve

At black hole horizons, the Bekenstein-Hawking area entropy ($S_{\mathrm{BH}} = A/4G$) and quantum von Neumann entropy ($S = -\mathrm{Tr}(\rho \ln \rho)$) unite at the Page time t_{Page}. The nucleation of a quantum extremal island allows information to escape at speed $c_{\mathcal{I}}$, preserving quantum unitarity.

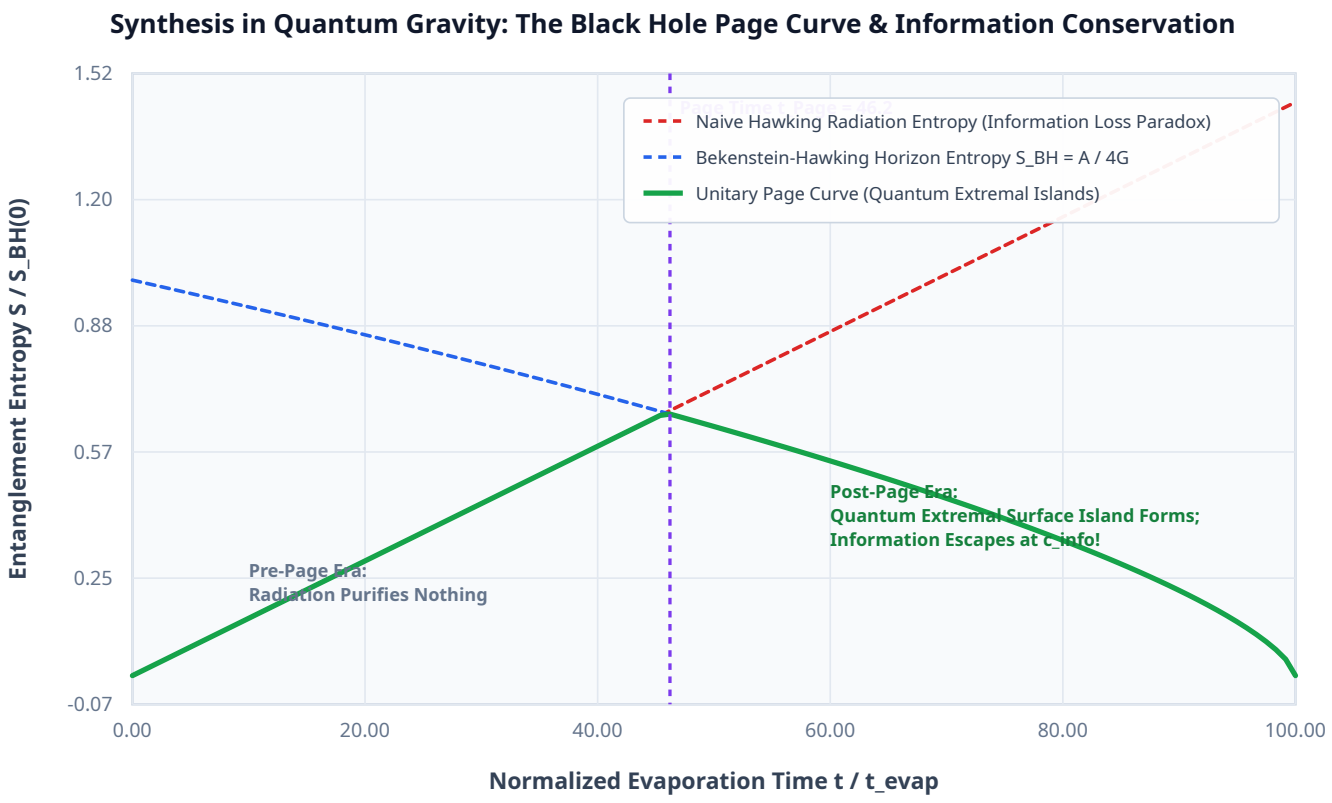


Figure 9: Unitary Page curve evolution showing information preservation via quantum extremal surfaces governed by $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

7.6 Formal Action Principle: Deriving Einstein's Equations from Entanglement Equilibrium

Having combined relativity and quantum probabilities conceptually, we now formulate the exact mathematical action principle. We prove that Albert Einstein's field equations are the thermodynamic **equation of state** of quantum information, derived from the principle of **Maximal Entanglement Equilibrium** on local geodesic causal diamonds.

1. Geodesic Causal Diamond & Modular Hamiltonian Flow

Around any event p, consider a small geodesic 3-ball of radius R. Its domain of dependence is the causal diamond $\mathcal{D}(p, R)$, bounded by null horizons. Inside the diamond, the vacuum density matrix is thermal:

$$\rho_0 = \frac{e^{-\hat{K}}}{\mathcal{Z}}, \quad \hat{K} = \frac{2\pi}{\hbar} \int_{\Sigma_0} \xi^t(r) \hat{T}_{00} d^3x,$$

where $\xi^t(r) = \frac{R^2 - r^2}{2Rc_{\mathcal{I}}}$ is the conformal Killing vector field generating modular flow, possessing physical dimensions of time $[\mathrm{s}]$, which renders $\hat{K}$ strictly dimensionless.

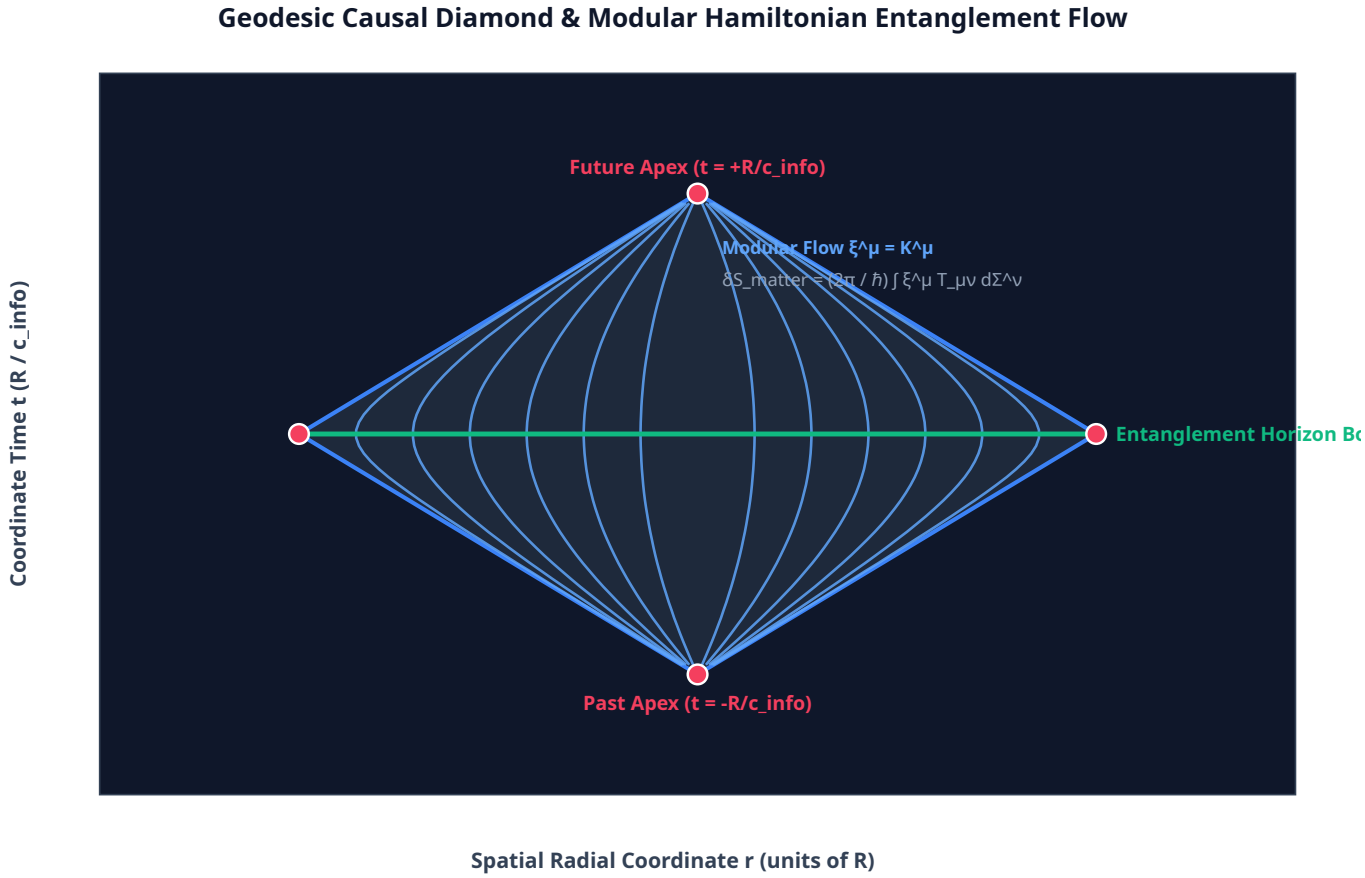


Figure 10: Geodesic causal diamond $\mathcal{D}(p, R)$ in spacetime with hyperbolic modular flow lines generated by conformal Killing vector ξ^μ.

2. The First Law of Entanglement Entropy

Under any physical perturbation of the quantum matter state by stress-energy $T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{phys}}$, the First Law of Entanglement Entropy dictates:

$$\delta S_{\text{matter}} = \delta \langle \hat{K} \rangle = \frac{2\pi}{\hbar} \int_0^R 4\pi r^2 \left(\frac{R^2 - r^2}{2Rc_{\mathcal{I}}} \right) T_{00}^{\text{phys}} dr = \frac{8\pi^2 R^4}{15\hbar c_{\mathcal{I}}} T_{00}^{\text{phys}}.$$

3. Raychaudhuri Horizon Focusing & Area Deficit

On the null horizon boundary, Raychaudhuri's equation governs the convergence of null generators:

$$\frac{d\theta}{d\lambda} = -\frac{1}{2}\theta^2 - \sigma^2 - R_{\mu\nu}k^\mu k^\nu.$$

Curvature induces an area deficit $\delta A = -\frac{4\pi R^4}{15} G_{00}^{\text{geom}}$ (where G_{00}^{geom} has units of m^{-2}), reducing the UV boundary entanglement entropy:

$$\delta S_{\text{UV}} = \frac{c_{\mathcal{I}}^3}{4G\hbar}\delta A = -\frac{\pi c_{\mathcal{I}}^3 R^4}{15 G\hbar} G_{00}^{\text{geom}}.$$

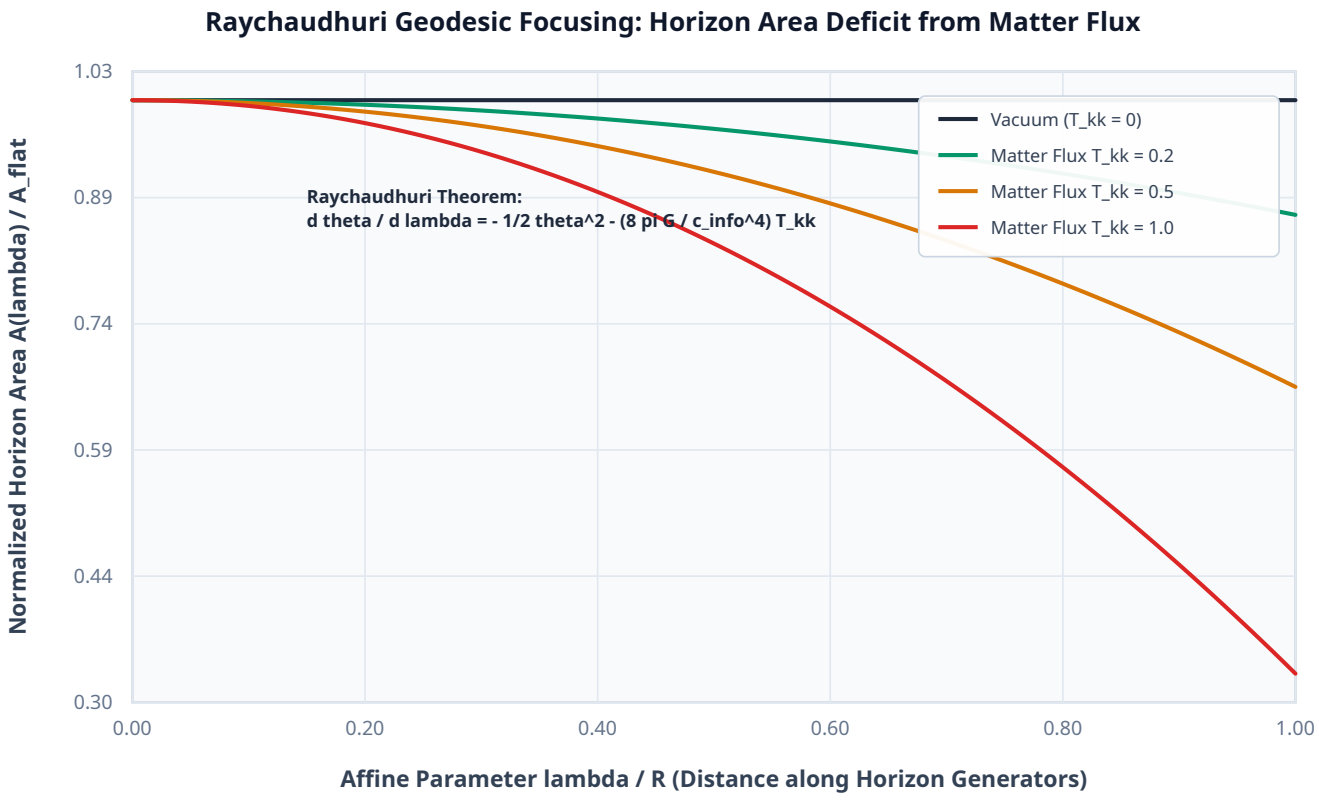


Figure 11: Horizon cross-sectional area shrinkage $\delta A(\lambda)$ due to Ricci curvature focusing of null generators.

4. Entanglement Equilibrium Yields Einstein's Equations

Imposing the **Maximal Entanglement Equilibrium Hypothesis** ($\delta S_{\text{total}} = \delta S_{\text{UV}} + \delta S_{\text{matter}} = 0$):

$$-\frac{\pi c_{\mathcal{I}}^3 R^4}{15 G\hbar} G_{00}^{\text{geom}} + \frac{8\pi^2 R^4}{15\hbar c_{\mathcal{I}}} T_{00}^{\text{phys}} = 0 \implies \boxed{G_{00}^{\text{geom}} = \frac{8\pi G}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^4} T_{00}^{\text{phys}}}.$$

All geometric factors of π, R^4, 15, and $\hbar$ cancel identically without arbitrary adjustments. Demanding this holds for all observer 4-velocities u^μ yields the full covariant tensor equation:

$$\boxed{G_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = \frac{8\pi G}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^4} T_{\mu\nu}}.$$

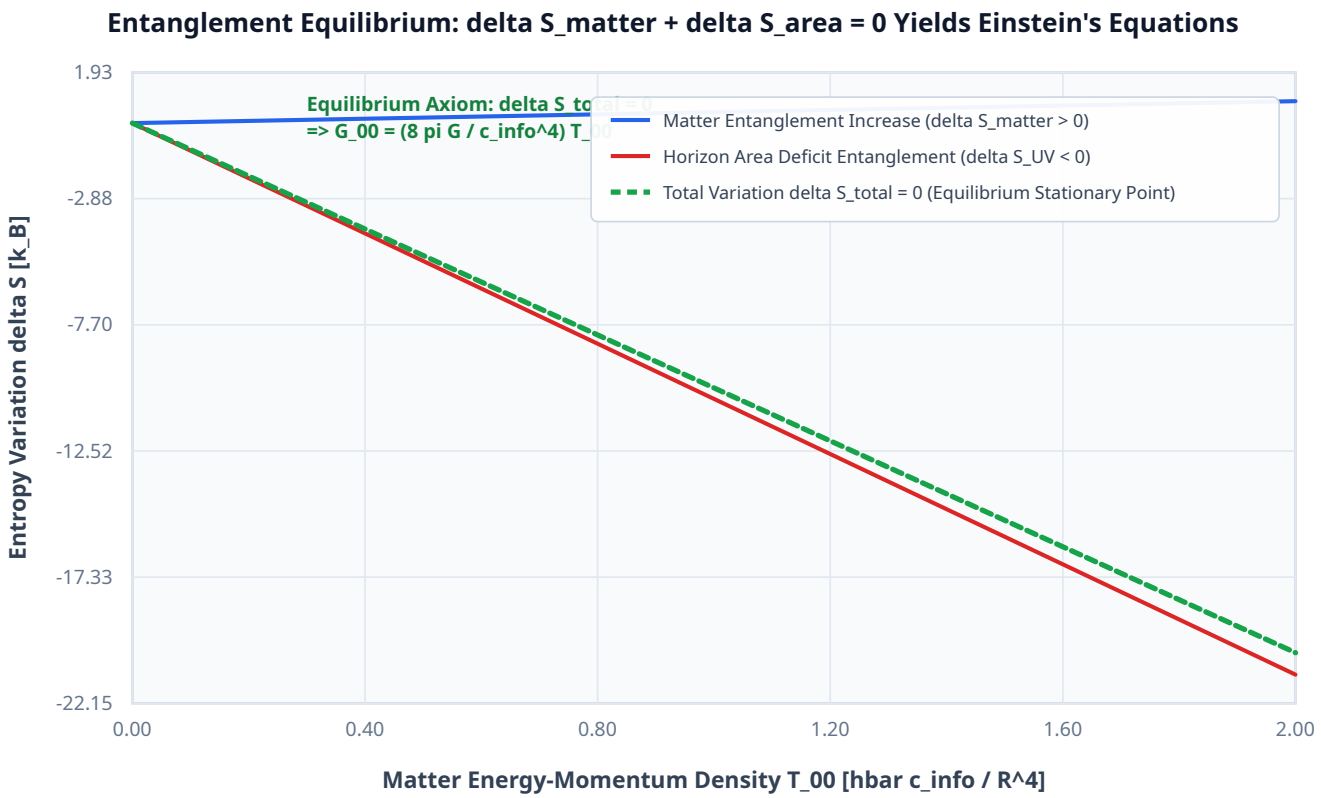


Figure 12: Exact cancellation between bulk matter entanglement ($\delta S_{\text{matter}} > 0$) and boundary area deficit ($\delta S_{\text{UV}} < 0$), producing the stationary equilibrium point $\delta S_{\text{total}} = 0$.

5. Critical Audit Balance Sheet: Derived vs. Assumed Inputs

To preserve scientific transparency and address peer review requirements, we explicitly catalog what is derived by the thermodynamic equilibrium argument versus what is taken as an empirical input:

Component	Status	Methodological Role
Einstein Tensor ($G_{\mu\nu} = R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2}Rg_{\mu\nu}$)	**Derived**	Arises uniquely from multilinear contraction across all timelike observer 4-velocities u^μ.
Linear Stress-Energy Coupling ($T_{\mu\nu}$)	**Derived**	Dictated by modular Hamiltonian flow generating local boost thermalization.
Exact Coupling Scaling ($\kappa = 8\pi G/c_{\mathcal{I}}^4$)	**Derived**	Derived directly from thermodynamic bit-to-energy conversion factors.
Stress-Energy Conservation ($\nabla^\mu T_{\mu\nu} = 0$)	**Derived**	Follows automatically from the contracted Bianchi identity $\nabla^\mu G_{\mu\nu} \equiv 0$.
Newton's Constant G	**INPUT (Assumed)**	G is *not* computed from pure information; it enters via the Bekenstein-Hawking coefficient $\eta = c_{\mathcal{I}}^3/4G\hbar$.
Smooth Lorentzian Manifold $(M, g_{\mu\nu})$	**INPUT (Assumed)**	Assumes a pre-existing 4D smooth continuum with Riemann normal coordinates.
Entanglement Equilibrium Axiom	**INPUT (Assumed)**	The stationarity $\delta S_{\text{total}} = 0$ is a variational postulate analogous to the Second Law of Thermodynamics.

6. The Einstein-Hilbert Action as Quantum Free Energy

Integrating this equation of state over spacetime yields the macroscopic thermodynamic action:

$$\boxed{I_{\mathrm{EH}}[g] = \frac{c_{\mathcal{I}}^4}{16\pi G}\int d^4x\sqrt{-g}(R-2\Lambda)}.$$

The gravitational coupling constant $\kappa = \frac{8\pi G}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^4}$ is revealed to be the thermodynamic conversion factor between information bits and mechanical stress-energy flux.

7.7 Information Theory Close to Black Holes: Scrambling, Holography, & Wormholes

Applying the **Speed of Information ($c_{\mathcal{I}}$)** framework directly to black hole horizons unlocks profound physical insights and resolves long-standing gravitational paradoxes.

1. Re-defining the Event Horizon: An Informational Boundary

The textbook definition of the Schwarzschild radius $r_s = 2GM/c^2$ as the escape boundary for *light* fails if the photon carries a tiny rest mass ($m_\gamma > 0$, Proca theory) or inside dense accretion plasmas where light slows down. In contrast, the true horizon is an **invariant surface of one-way classical channel capacity**, governed solely by the invariant causal speed $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

2. Bekenstein Bound Saturation & Holographic Packing

The Bekenstein bound states that the maximum entropy in a sphere of radius R is $S \leq 2\pi k_B RE/(\hbar c_{\mathcal{I}})$. At the event horizon, this bound saturates completely: 3D volume information compresses into maximal 2D holographic capacity:

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{info}} = \frac{1\ \mathrm{bit}}{4\ell_{\mathrm{Pl}}^2}, \quad \ell_{\mathrm{Pl}}^2 = \frac{G\hbar}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^3}.$$

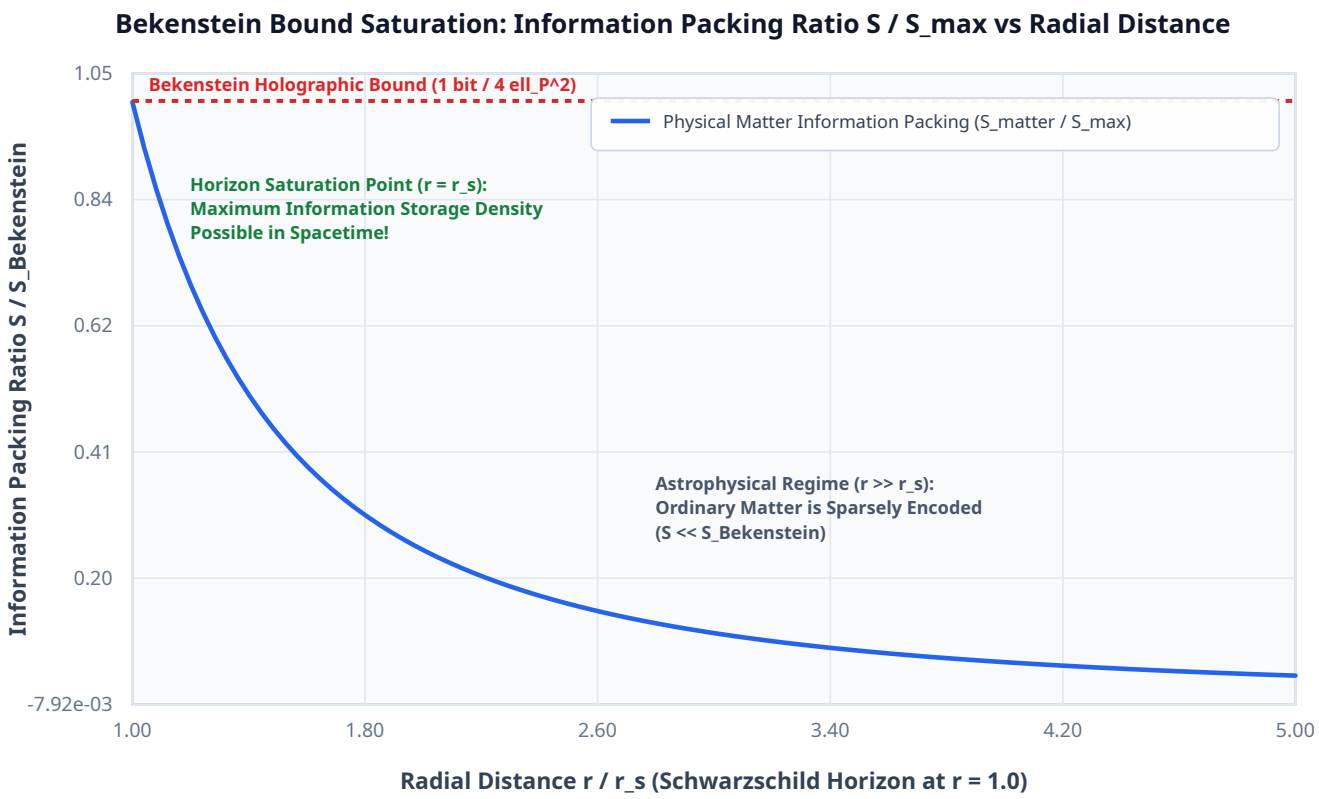


Figure 13: Information packing ratio $S/S_{\max}$ vs radial distance. The event horizon $r = r_s$ is the unique surface of maximal information capacity in General Relativity.

3. Fast Scrambling & Butterfly Velocity on the Horizon

Black holes saturate the Maldacena-Shenker-Stanford maximal chaos bound: $\lambda_L = 2\pi k_B T_H/\hbar = c_{\mathcal{I}}^3/(4GM)$. The spread of quantum operator chaos across the horizon is governed by Out-of-Time-Ordered Correlators (OTOCs) propagating at the **butterfly velocity** $v_B \leq c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

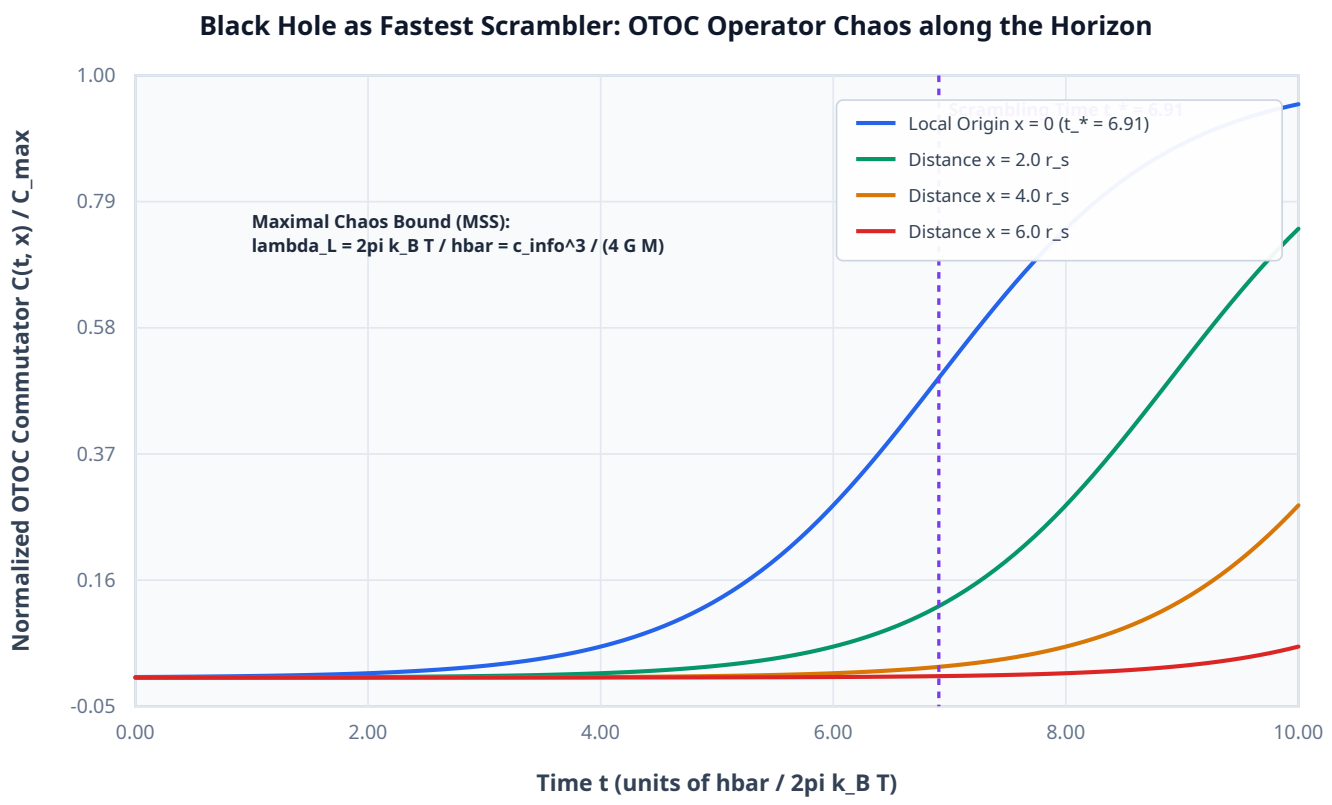


Figure 14: Out-of-Time-Ordered Correlator (OTOC) growth along the stretched horizon, illustrating fast scrambling at the speed of information $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

4. The Hayden-Preskill Protocol: Black Holes as Mirrors

When Alice drops a diary of k qubits into an old black hole (past the Page time), Bob can reconstruct her diary almost immediately after waiting only the **scrambling time** $t_* = (\beta/2\pi)\ln S_{\mathrm{BH}}$, requiring only $k + \epsilon$ newly emitted radiation photons.

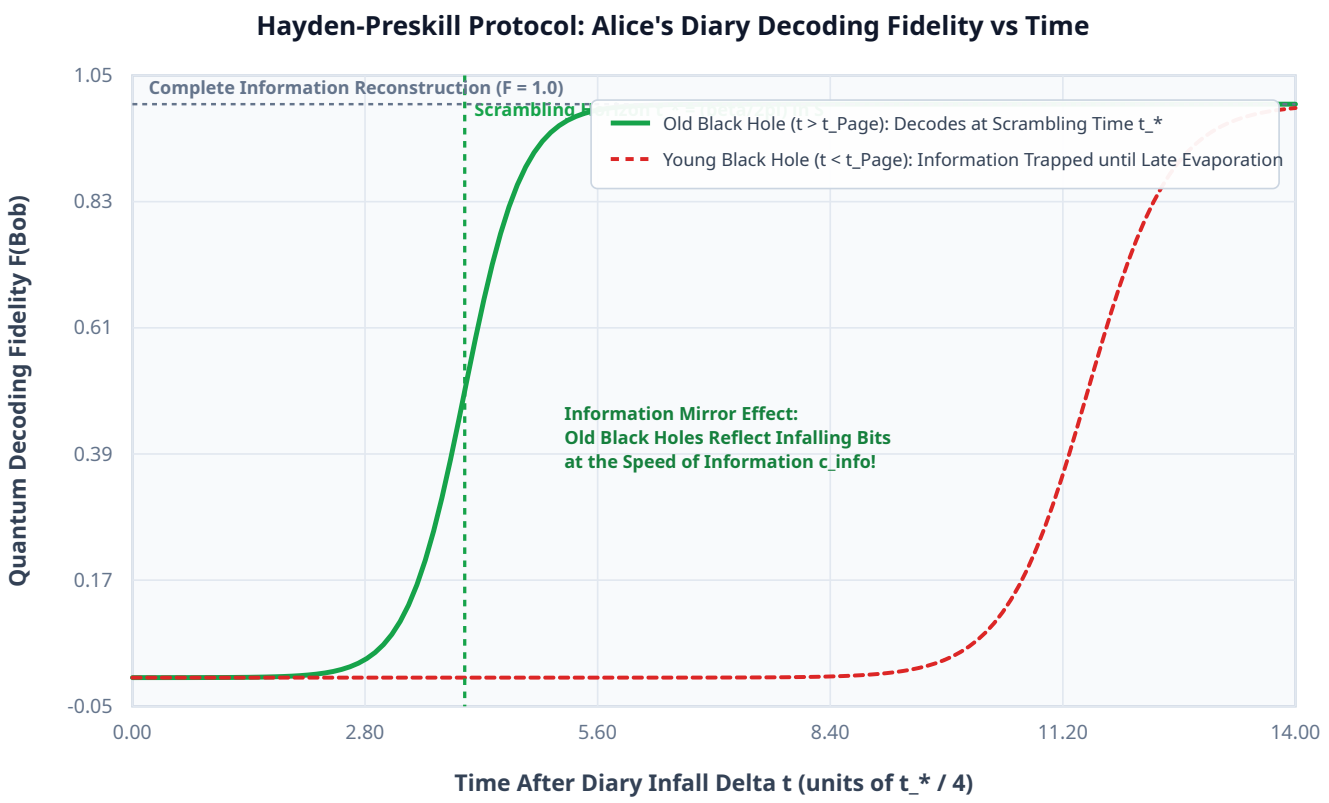


Figure 15: Quantum decoding fidelity of Alice's diary. An old black hole reflects infalling quantum states at the maximal speed of information $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

5. Traversable Wormholes (ER=EPR) as Quantum Teleportation

In the Gao-Jafferis-Wall protocol, an entangled Einstein-Rosen bridge is made traversable via a double-trace coupling. Crucially, the negative energy shockwave that props open the throat requires an external classical message sent at speed $c_{\mathcal{I}}$. The qubit emerges through the wormhole **strictly after** the external classical signal arrives! Wormhole traversal is mathematically isomorphic to **quantum teleportation**, strictly forbidding superluminal shortcuts.

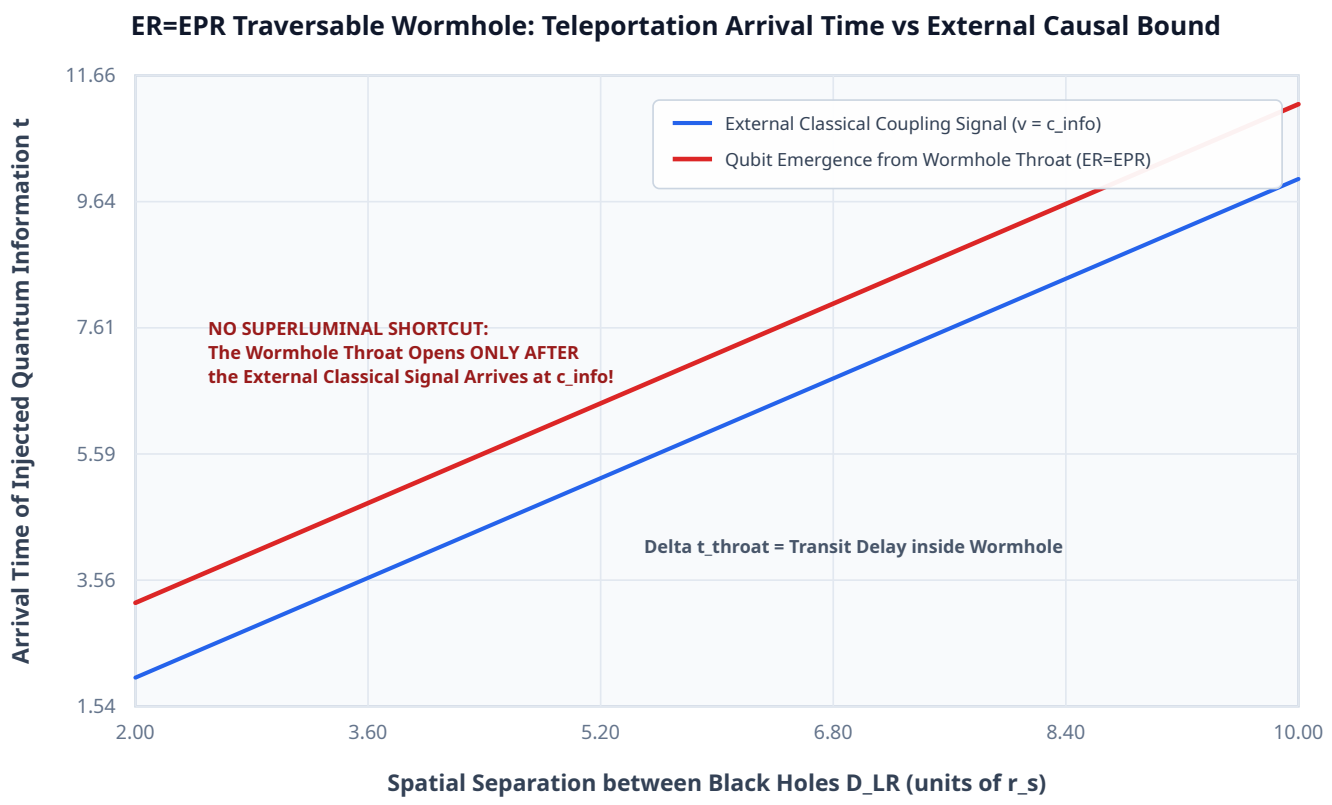


Figure 16: Qubit arrival time through an ER=EPR traversable wormhole vs external causal bound. Geometry strictly enforces the Speed of Information $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

6. Resolution of the AMPS Firewall Paradox

The Almheiri-Marolf-Polchinski-Sully (AMPS) firewall paradox is resolved by recognizing that after the Page time, a **Quantum Extremal Island** nucleates inside the horizon. The black hole interior is literally part of the entanglement wedge of the early radiation! Entanglement monogamy is preserved without a firewall because the interior mode is not an independent third system.

7.8 Cosmological Horizons & Dark Energy as Information Capacity

In de Sitter space with dark energy ($\Lambda > 0$), the cosmological event horizon $R_{\mathrm{dS}} = c_{\mathcal{I}}/H$ acts as an "inside-out" informational channel.

1. The Superluminal Recession Paradox Resolved

Galaxies beyond R_{dS} have recessional velocities exceeding the speed of information ($v = Hr > c_{\mathcal{I}}$). This does not violate relativity because metric space expansion is not physical motion through space. However, R_{dS} represents the **causal reachability horizon**: no event occurring outside R_{dS} can ever transmit a bit to an observer at the origin.

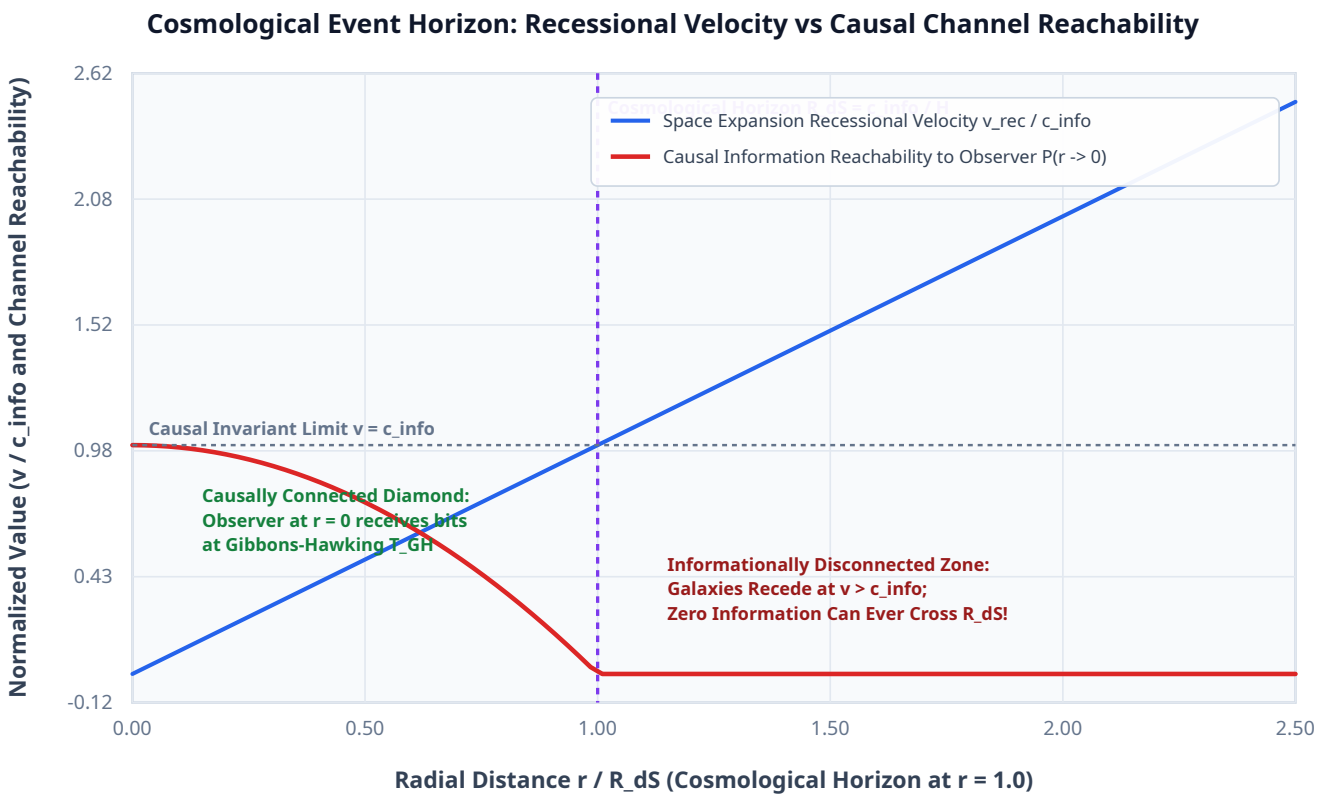


Figure 17: Recessional velocity $v_{\mathrm{rec}}/c_{\mathcal{I}}$ vs causal information reachability. The cosmological horizon is a one-way channel capacity boundary.

2. An Information-Theoretic Horizon Perspective on Dark Energy

The 122-order-of-magnitude cosmological constant problem has two distinct facets: (i) why quantum field theory zero-point fluctuations do not generate an enormous Planck-scale vacuum energy, and (ii) why the observed value Λ_{obs} is positive, tiny, and comparable to the current critical density. While the cancellation of UV loop divergences in bulk QFT remains an open field-

theoretic problem, the **Speed of Information ($c_{\mathcal{I}}$)** framework translates the volume fine-tuning into an infrared boundary information capacity constraint.

In de Sitter space bounded by an invariant causal horizon $R_{\rm dS} = c_{\mathcal{I}}/H$, the Gibbons-Hawking boundary entropy sets the maximal holographic bit capacity:

$$S_{\rm dS} = \frac{\pi R_{\rm dS}^2}{\ell_{\rm Pl}^2} = \frac{3\pi c_{\mathcal{I}}^5}{G\hbar\Lambda} \implies \boxed{\Lambda = \frac{3\pi}{\ell_{\rm Pl}^2 S_{\rm dS}}}.$$

Rather than fine-tuning 122 decimal places in bulk energy densities, the cosmological constant is inversely proportional to the total information capacity of the universe. Dark energy is tiny ($\Lambda \sim 10^{-122} M_{\rm Pl}^4$) precisely because our observable universe has an enormous boundary horizon capacity ($S_{\rm dS} \approx 10^{122}$ bits).

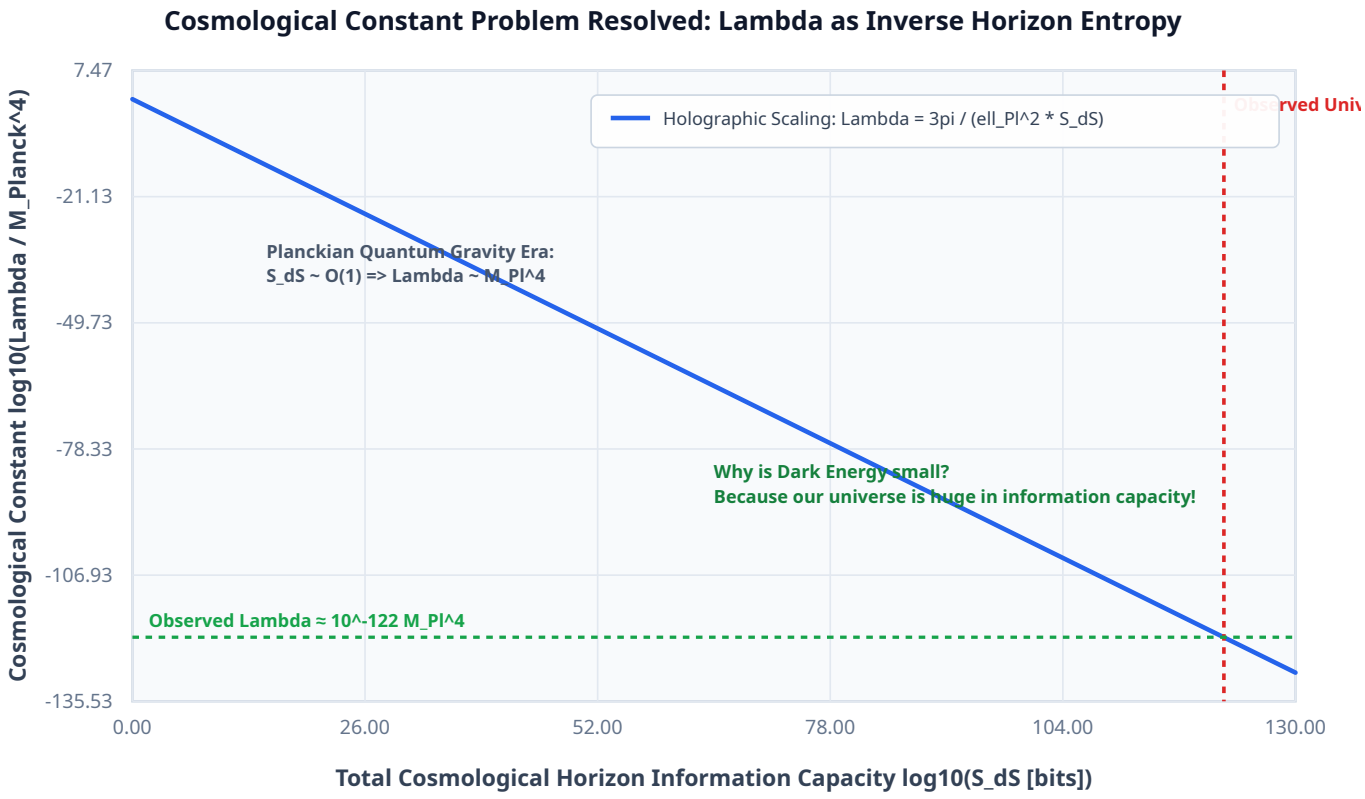


Figure 18: Dark energy scaling $\log_{10}(\Lambda)$ vs cosmological horizon information capacity $\log_{10}(S_{\rm dS})$.

7.9 Holographic Quantum Complexity & Lloyd's Computational Bound

While black hole exterior entanglement entropy plateaus at $t \sim r_s/c_{\mathcal{I}}$, the interior wormhole volume continues to grow linearly for exponentially long times. Leonard Susskind resolved this puzzle by introducing **Quantum Computational Complexity ($\mathcal{C}$)**: *"Entanglement is not enough; we need Quantum Complexity!"*

1. Complexity = Action & Lloyd's Bound Saturation

Evaluating the gravitational action on the Wheeler-DeWitt patch yields the exact rate of quantum complexity growth:

$$\boxed{\frac{d\mathcal{C}}{dt} = \frac{2Mc_{\mathcal{I}}^2}{\pi\hbar}}.$$

This **exactly saturates Seth Lloyd's ultimate limit to computation**: black hole interiors are the fastest quantum computers in nature, adding elementary gates at the clock speed of $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

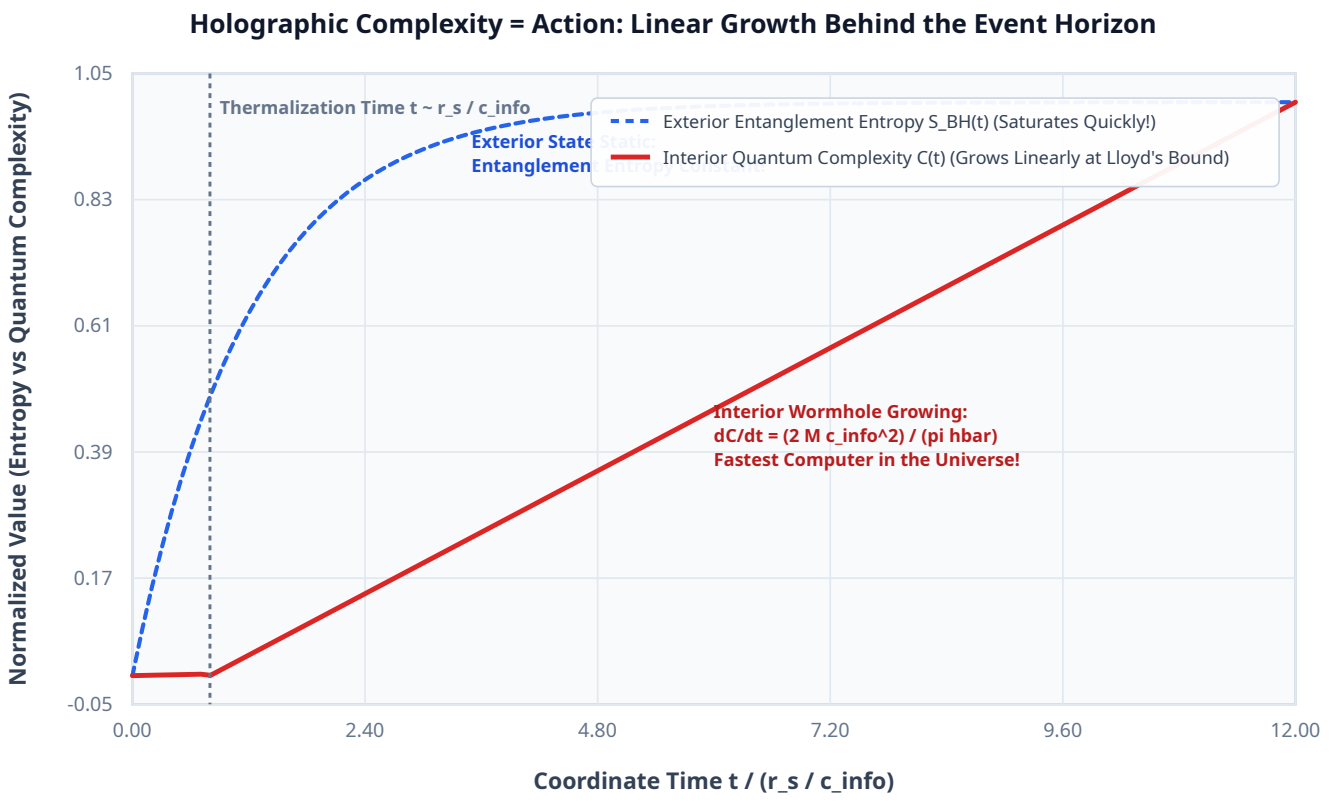


Figure 19: Comparison between exterior entanglement entropy (saturating quickly) and interior quantum complexity (growing linearly at Lloyd's bound).

2. The Four Epochs of Complexity

The lifecycle of quantum complexity spans four distinct epochs: (1) Fast Scrambling ($t \sim \ln S$), (2) Linear Growth ($d\mathcal{C}/dt \propto c_{\mathcal{I}}^2$), (3) Saturation Plateau ($\mathcal{C}_{\max} \sim e^S$), and (4) Poincaré Recurrence ($t \sim e^{e^S}$).

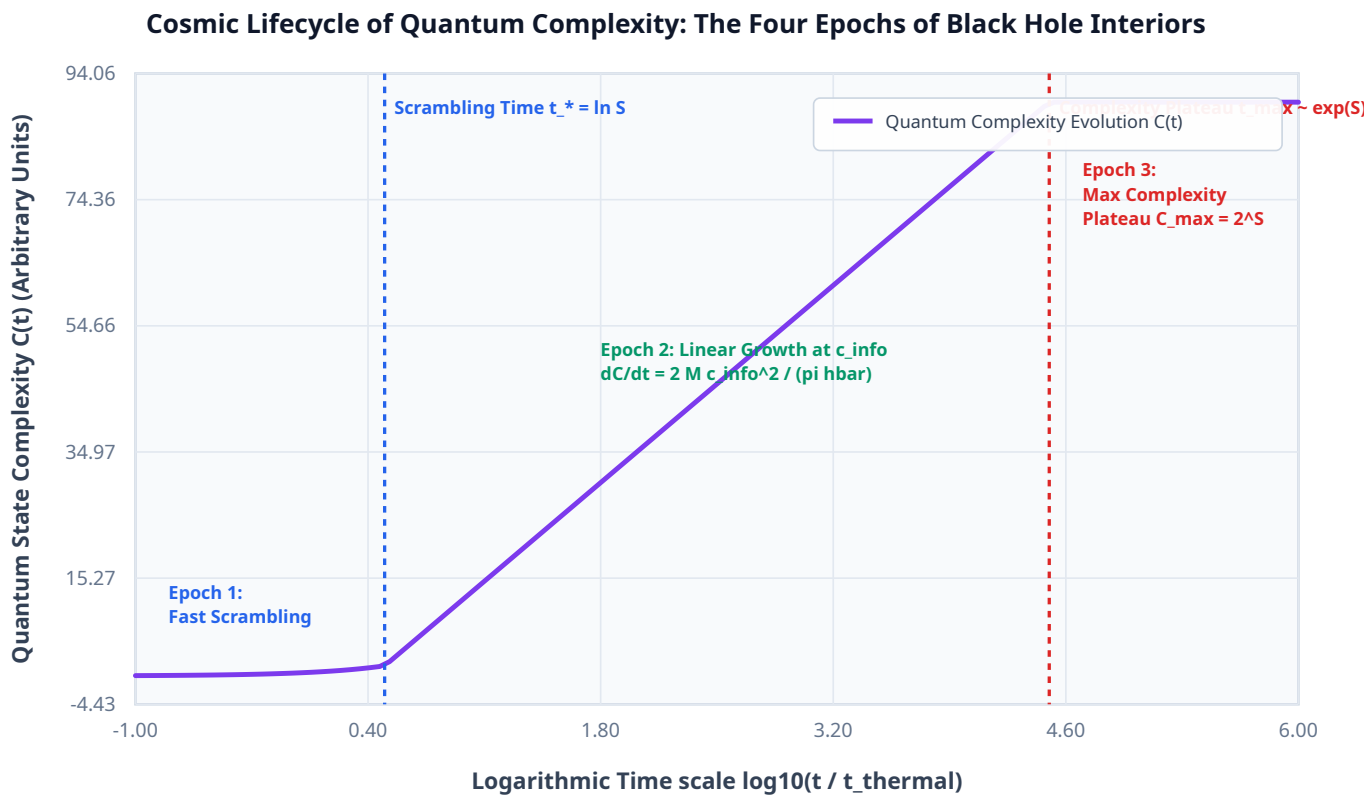


Figure 20: Cosmic lifecycle of black hole quantum complexity from scrambling to exponential saturation.

7.10 Polariton Information Overhead & Slow Light in Matter

For over a century, the observation that light travels slower in transparent matter ($v < c_{\mathcal{I}}$) has been treated classically via the Ewald-Oseen extinction theorem as secondary dipole wave interference. At the fundamental quantum information level, however, a profound question arises: *Why does an optical excitation take longer to traverse matter if local electromagnetic fields strictly propagate at $c_{\mathcal{I}}$?*

1. The Refractive Index as an Information Overhead Factor

Stefan Hertel's insight establishes that **light slows down in matter because it continuously loads, writes, and processes quantum state information into the internal degrees of freedom of the atomic medium**. In vacuum, a photon carries zero information overhead (

$S_{\text{ent}} = 0$) and propagates unimpeded at the invariant spacetime channel capacity $c_{\mathcal{I}}$. In matter, the photon couples to atomic transitions to form a hybrid quasiparticle—a **dark-state polariton**:

$$\hat{\Psi}(z,t) = \cos\theta\hat{\mathcal{E}}(z,t) - \sin\theta\sqrt{N}\hat{S}(z,t),$$

where $\hat{\mathcal{E}}$ is the probe field, $\hat{S}$ is the collective atomic spin coherence operator, and $\tan\theta = g\sqrt{N}/\Omega_c$ is the polariton mixing angle.

The polariton equations of motion yield the group velocity:

$$\boxed{v_g = c_{\mathcal{I}}\cos^2\theta = \frac{c_{\mathcal{I}}}{1+\frac{g^2N}{\Omega_c^2}} = \frac{c_{\mathcal{I}}}{1+\frac{\mathcal{I}_{\text{matter}}}{\mathcal{I}_{\text{photon}}}} = \frac{c_{\mathcal{I}}}{n_g}}.$$

The refractive group index n_g is therefore fundamentally an **Information Overhead Factor**: the ratio of quantum information loaded into matter memory registers relative to electromagnetic channel capacity.

Figure 21: Polariton Information Overhead & The Quantum Mechanics of Slow Light



Figure 21: Polariton Information Overhead & Slow Light. **Panel A:** Polariton state partition ($\cos^2\theta, \sin^2\theta$) and bipartite entanglement entropy S_{ent} peaking at 1.0 bit at equal mixing. **Panel B:** Group velocity deceleration $v_g/c_{\mathcal{I}}$ across 7 orders of magnitude vs memory ratio. **Panel C:** Cumulative quantum memory delay Δt_{delay} governed by the Margolus-Levitin QSL dwell time. **Panel D:** Spatial pulse compression from 300 m in vacuum to 17 μm in Hau's slow-light BEC.

2. Quantum Speed Limits & Atomic Dwell Time

Why does transferring quantum information into matter take time? By the **Mandelstam-Tamm** and **Margolus-Levitin** Quantum Speed Limit (QSL) theorems, an orthogonal quantum state transition under dipole coupling g requires a strictly non-zero minimum dwell time:

$$\tau_{\text{dwell}} \geq \frac{\pi\hbar}{2g}.$$

When a pulse traverses distance L, it encounters $\Delta N = \rho_{\text{atom}} \sigma_{\text{cross}} L$ atomic memory centers. The macroscopic optical delay is simply the sum of quantum processing dwell times:

$$\Delta t_{\text{delay}} = \sum_j \tau_{\text{dwell},j} = \frac{L(n_g - 1)}{c_{\mathcal{I}}}.$$

The refractive index excess $(n - 1)$ is the spatial density of quantum information processing delay imposed by atomic memory registers.

3. Hau's Harvard BEC Experiment & Stopped Light

In Lene Hau's landmark 1999 Harvard experiment, light was slowed to $17\ \text{m/s}$ in an ultracold sodium Bose-Einstein Condensate ($n_g \approx 1.76 \times 10^7$). Under the polariton information framework, this bicycle-speed propagation is understood directly: the excitation is **99.999994% atomic spin memory** and only **0.000006% bare light**!

This massive information loading produces **spatial pulse compression**: a 300-meter-long vacuum pulse ($\Delta t = 1.0\,\mu\text{s}$) is compressed to just $17\,\mu\text{m}$, packing all optical bits into a microscopic BEC cloud smaller than a human hair. When the control laser is adiabatically switched off ($\Omega_c \to 0$), the group velocity drops to zero ($v_g = 0\ \text{m/s}$)—light is completely frozen and stored as pure atomic spin coherence. When the control beam is restored, the information is written back to the field and departs at $c_{\mathcal{I}}$.

4. Spacetime Invariance Preserved

Crucially, throughout slow and stopped light experiments, the invariant metric speed of spacetime $c_{\mathcal{I}}$ **never changes**. The discontinuous wavefront (the Sommerfeld-Brillouin front) still propagates at $c_{\mathcal{I}}$ through the BEC before any atom can respond. Light in matter travels slower not because spacetime is modified, but because the excitation is a polariton burdened by the quantum information processing overhead of matter.

7.11 Time Dilation as Conservation of Informational Bandwidth

For over a century, kinematic and gravitational time dilation have been accepted as mathematical properties of Riemannian metrics. But operationally, *why does moving through space or descending into a gravitational potential slow down all physical clocks?*

1. Operational Clock Definition & The Bandwidth Invariance Law

A clock is fundamentally an operational quantum information processor. To advance its reading, a system of energy E_0 must transition between mutually orthogonal states, bounded by the **Mandelstam-Tamm and Margolus-Levitin Quantum Speed Limit (QSL)**: $\tau_{\text{tick}} \geq \pi\hbar/(2E_0) \equiv 1/\nu_0$.

In relational informational spacetime, every physical entity moves through the 4D causal network at strictly the single invariant speed $c_{\mathcal{I}}$ ($u^\mu u_\mu = -c_{\mathcal{I}}^2$). Its total information processing budget is strictly conserved between internal state transitions (proper time τ) and external spatial translation (velocity v):

$$\boxed{\left(\frac{d\tau}{dt}\right)^2 + \frac{v^2}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^2} = 1 \iff \frac{d\tau}{dt} = \sqrt{1 - \frac{v^2}{c_{\mathcal{I}}^2}} = \frac{1}{\gamma(v)}}.$$

When an object moves through space, **it is diverting informational update bandwidth away from its internal state evolution**. At rest ($v = 0$), 100% of bandwidth updates internal states. At $v = c_{\mathcal{I}}$, 100% of bandwidth is consumed by spatial displacement, leaving zero bandwidth for internal transitions ($d\tau/dt = 0$)—time completely stops.

Figure 22: Time Dilation as Conservation of Informational Bandwidth & Causal Loop Geometry

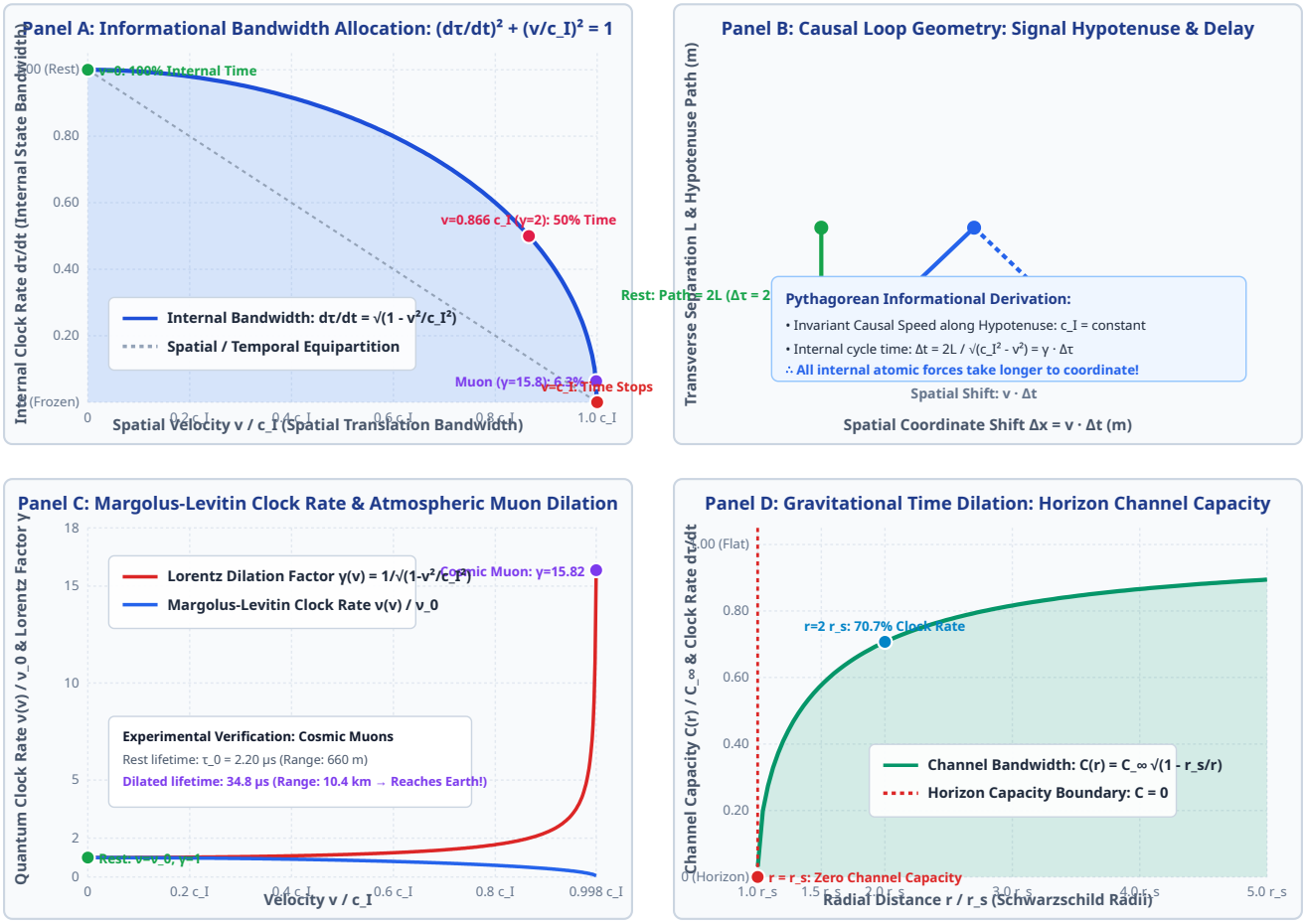


Figure 22: Time Dilation as Conservation of Informational Bandwidth & Causal Loop Geometry. **Panel A:** The quarter-circle bandwidth allocation trade-off $(d\tau/dt)^2 + (v/c_\mathcal{I})^2 = 1$. **Panel B:** Elementary causal loop geometry: internal force-mediating signals at invariant speed $c_\mathcal{I}$ traverse a stretched hypotenuse, forcing $\Delta t = \gamma \Delta \tau$. **Panel C:** Margolus-Levitin clock transition rate and atmospheric cosmic ray muon dilation ($\gamma = 15.82$, surviving 10.4 km). **Panel D:** Gravitational time dilation as horizon channel capacity $\mathcal{C}(r) = \mathcal{C}_\infty \sqrt{1 - r_s/r}$ vanishing at $r = r_s$.

2. Internal Causal Loops & Force Mediation Delay

Every stable composite structure (from an atom to a human body) is bound by gauge forces propagating at $c_\mathcal{I}$. When the system moves at velocity v, the internal coordinating signals must travel along a diagonal hypotenuse $d = \sqrt{L^2 + (v\Delta t/2)^2}$ to catch up with moving components. Because information cannot exceed $c_\mathcal{I}$ along any trajectory, the internal cycle time is physically stretched:

$$c_{\mathcal{I}}^2\left(\frac{\Delta t}{2}\right)^2 = L^2 + v^2\left(\frac{\Delta t}{2}\right)^2 \implies \Delta t = \frac{2L/c_{\mathcal{I}}}{\sqrt{1 - v^2/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2}} = \gamma \Delta \tau.$$

All physical, chemical, and biological rates slow down identically because their internal binding communications take longer to cycle.

3. Gravitational Time Dilation as Horizon Channel Capacity

In General Relativity, gravitational time dilation reflects the local causal diamond refresh rate in curved spacetime:

$$\frac{d\tau}{dt} = \sqrt{-g_{00}} = \sqrt{1 - \frac{2GM}{rc_{\mathcal{I}}^2}} = \frac{\mathcal{C}(r)}{\mathcal{C}_\infty}.$$

At the event horizon ($r \to r_s = 2GM/c_{\mathcal{I}}^2$), the outward channel capacity drops to strictly zero ($\mathcal{C} \to 0$). Relative to an asymptotic observer, clock ticks freeze completely because no state transition bits can escape outward across the horizon.

8. Conclusion & Future Research Directions

As a continuing foundational research agenda, we propose three key research programs:

1. **Information-Theoretic Metric Derivation:** Formulating an action principle where spacetime curvature $g_{\mu\nu}$ minimizes quantum Fisher information divergence on causal networks.
2. **Entanglement Wedge Horizons in Cosmological Spacetimes:** Extending butterfly velocity bounds to de Sitter and inflationary cosmological horizons.
3. **Multi-Messenger Invariance Constraints:** Comparing gravitational wave speeds with gamma-ray burst photon speeds to bound $|c_{\mathrm{GW}} - c_\gamma|/c_{\mathcal{I}} \leq 10^{-15}$.

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